The Wonderful Wizard of Oz

A simplified retelling

Original story by L. Frank Baum

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A house in the air

Dorothy lived on a grey Kansas farm with Aunt Em, Uncle Henry and her dog, Toto. One day, a cyclone approached. Before Dorothy could reach the shelter, the house rose into the air with her and Toto inside.

After a long journey, it landed in a strange country. Little people and the Good Witch of the North welcomed her. Her house had fallen on the Wicked Witch of the East and killed her, freeing the Munchkins from her rule.

Dorothy had not intended to harm anyone. She wanted only to return to Kansas. The Good Witch gave her the dead witch’s silver shoes and told her to follow the yellow brick road to the Emerald City. The Wizard of Oz might know how to send her home.

The witch also kissed Dorothy’s forehead, leaving a protective mark. Then Dorothy began walking, with no clear idea of how far home had become.

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2. Three companions

Beside the road, Dorothy found a Scarecrow fixed to a pole. She helped him down. He wanted a brain, believing that without one he could never be truly useful.

In the forest, they discovered a Tin Woodman whose joints had rusted. Dorothy found oil and freed him. He wanted a heart so that he could love again.

Then a Lion rushed out to frighten them. When he threatened Toto, Dorothy struck his nose. He admitted that he was ashamed of being a coward. He wanted courage.

All three joined her journey to Oz. Along the way, the Scarecrow solved problems, the Tin Woodman worried about hurting small creatures, and the Lion faced dangers while afraid.

They did not notice how often their actions already contained the qualities they believed they lacked. Each imagined that the Wizard could give them something more definite than their own experience.

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3. Poppies and green spectacles

The travellers crossed a dangerous gap and a river. When they reached a field of poppies, Dorothy and the Lion fell asleep under the flowers' powerful influence.

The Scarecrow and Tin Woodman carried Dorothy to safety, but the Lion was too heavy. Help came after the Tin Woodman rescued the Queen of the Field Mice from a wildcat. The mice worked together to pull the Lion out.

At last, the companions reached the Emerald City. Before entering, they had to wear green spectacles. Everything around them seemed brilliantly green, from the buildings to the clothes.

They were received separately by the Wizard. To each visitor, he appeared in a different astonishing form. Each made a request, and each received a condition: they must defeat the Wicked Witch of the West.

Dorothy was frightened and disappointed. She had come for help, not to be sent against a dangerous ruler. Yet she saw no other way to obtain what she needed.

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4. The Wicked Witch of the West

The witch watched them approaching and sent wolves, crows and bees to stop them. The companions protected one another. Finally, she used a Golden Cap to command the Winged Monkeys.

The monkeys tore the Scarecrow apart, damaged the Tin Woodman and captured the Lion. They brought Dorothy to the witch but would not harm her because of the Good Witch’s protective mark.

Dorothy was forced to work. The witch wanted her silver shoes and managed to trick her out of one. Angry at the deception, Dorothy threw a bucket of water over her.

The witch began to melt. Dorothy had not known that water could destroy her. Within moments, the ruler who had frightened so many people was gone.

The Winkies, who had lived under her control, were free. They helped repair the Tin Woodman and put the Scarecrow together again. Dorothy found the Golden Cap and learned that it could summon the Winged Monkeys.

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5. Behind the curtain

The companions returned to the Emerald City and asked the Wizard to keep his promise. He delayed. Then Toto disturbed a screen, revealing an ordinary man operating the impressive effects.

Oz was not a great magician. He had arrived years earlier in a balloon and had allowed the people to believe he possessed extraordinary power.

The friends were shocked. Their dangerous journey had been demanded by someone who could not guarantee what he promised.

Still, he found ways to reassure them. He filled the Scarecrow’s head with a mixture that symbolised brains, gave the Tin Woodman a stuffed heart and offered the Lion a drink presented as courage. The objects did not create their abilities, but the friends now believed in themselves more readily.

For Dorothy, he proposed rebuilding a balloon. He planned to leave with her and named the Scarecrow as the city’s next ruler. But Toto ran into the crowd. Dorothy went after him, and the balloon rose without

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her.

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6. Another road

Dorothy was left behind again. She used the Golden Cap to call the Winged Monkeys, but they could not carry her beyond the boundaries of Oz.

She was advised to seek Glinda, the Good Witch of the South. Her friends refused to let her make the difficult journey alone.

They crossed a country of delicate china people, where careless movement could cause permanent harm. In another forest, the Lion defeated a monstrous spider that terrified the animals. They asked him to return as their ruler once he had helped Dorothy.

At a hill guarded by Hammer-Heads, the travellers could not pass safely. Dorothy used the Golden Cap again, and the monkeys carried them onward.

They had already defeated a witch and exposed a wizard. The journey still required help. Success did not make every new obstacle smaller or every old companion unnecessary.

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7. What the shoes could do

Glinda welcomed them. When she learned about Dorothy’s wish, she explained the power of the silver shoes. They could take their wearer anywhere she wanted to go.

Dorothy had possessed a way home since the beginning. But she had not known how to use it. Her friends, meanwhile, had found futures through the journey: the Scarecrow in the Emerald City, the Tin Woodman among the Winkies and the Lion in the forest.

Glinda arranged for the Winged Monkeys to carry the companions to their new homes, then freed the monkeys from the Golden Cap’s command.

Dorothy said goodbye, held Toto close and struck the heels of the shoes together. She asked to go home to Aunt Em.

The shoes carried her across the distance, then were lost along the way. Dorothy landed in Kansas and ran towards her aunt. The country was still plain and grey, but the people she loved were there.

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She had travelled through astonishing places. Returning did not make those places unimportant. It made the ordinary word “home” mean something she now understood more fully.

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Words to keep

Cyclone — a powerful rotating storm. A cyclone carried the farmhouse away.

Companion — someone who shares a journey or activity. Dorothy gained three companions.

Courage — acting despite fear. The Lion showed courage before he believed he possessed it.

Deception — making someone believe something false. The Wizard’s appearance depended on deception.

Symbol — an object that represents an idea. The stuffed heart served as a symbol.

Reassure — to help someone feel less worried or uncertain. The gifts reassured the companions.

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A question to carry with you

Why do the Scarecrow, Tin Woodman and Lion trust the Wizard’s gifts more readily than the evidence of their own actions?

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